University of Newcastle upon Tyne

School of Arts and Cultures

Fine Art

A Cross-cultural Study of Chinese *Yi Jing* Aesthetic Theory and *Ch'an* Philosophy Applied to Contemporary Art

Bright Moon Tender Wind

by

Chun-Chao Chiu

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comply with the basic idea of *Ch'an*, straightforward but deeply philosophical. Simplicity is however not as simple as we imagine. It can represent refinement which arises through complexity; this paradox is characteristic of *Ch'an*, which describes the immaterial as the material, therefore falsity and reality are happening at the same time. In painting, the colour, line, and brushstroke can represent anything, we cannot define it, but through it we can simply feel the rhythm of the universe.

I would like to use the example of the American painter Mark Tobey to illustrate some of these ideas as he is one of only a few artists who emerged at this time who actually went to the East and studied Eastern art. Tobey was born in Wisconsin, USA, in 1890 and converted himself into the Bahai faith – the oneness of the universe/unity of diversity in 1918. In the 1920's he became curious about Asian art and philosophy. In 1923, Tobey study Chinese calligraphy with a Chinese artist, Teng Kuei, and first used Chinese brush techniques in order to study linear form. In 1934 he spent about three and half months concentrating on the study of painting and calligraphy in Shanghai, China and Japan, and also stayed for a month in a *Ch'an* monastery near Kyoto. Tobey himself later describes this experience: "*...I studied brushwork, acquainting myself with some of the Oriental masters, and found out for myself that one could experience a tree in a dynamic line as well as in mass and light.*"[99]

Mark Tobey noted how the oriental influence on his work gave him a new version of the meaning of "abstract" leading him towards "*concentration and*

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[99] Lipton, Rothko, Smith, Tobey XXXIX Venice Biennale, under the auspices of The Museum of Art, New York. 1958